

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE CENTRAL AFRICAN REPUBLIC

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The Central African Republic is one of the world's poorest and most conflict-affected states — where armed groups and foreign paramilitaries hold much of the territory, where the resource wealth is captured by fighters, and where the safety of anyone inside must come before all else. Yet it holds a treasure of global importance: part of the **Congo Basin rainforest**, the second largest on earth, with its forest elephants gathering by the hundreds at famous clearings, its lowland gorillas, and the Indigenous forest peoples who have stewarded it for millennia. The same country is torn by a long conflict funded in part by its **diamonds and gold**, its forest pressed by **logging** and a poaching epidemic, and its resources caught up in arrangements that trade extraction for security. There is no landmark community victory to point to, and no one inside can safely resist. But the world has a genuine stake in this forest and its captured wealth, and the tools to act, from outside, are real.

Those who would defend the Central African Republic's environment cannot do so safely inside a conflict-torn land, but the tools from outside are real. The Congo Basin forest and its wildlife can be defended through **international and transboundary conservation** — the protected areas, the transboundary World Heritage stakes such as the Sangha Trinational, and the conservation partners who work the region. The diamonds and gold that fund the conflict can be pressed toward accountability through the **conflict-diamond and conflict-mineral certification and due-diligence frameworks**. The logging can be held to **international timber-legality and sustainability standards** in the world markets its wood reaches. The **capture of resources for security** — the arrangements that trade extraction for protection — can be documented and scrutinised through international investigative and transparency bodies. And the **international conservation, transparency, and humanitarian frameworks and partners** reach where domestic action cannot, while **rigorous documentation** grounds it all and needs no one inside. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The conflict is active and much of the land dangerous, so open domestic opposition is impossible and perilous. The resource wealth is held by armed groups and foreign paramilitaries, so change is slow and external. The certification and conflict-mineral frameworks are real but imperfect and criticised. There is no landmark victory to point to. And, above all, no one inside can be exposed, and the conflict zones and armed actors must be avoided entirely. So the work must be external, conservation- and accountability-framed, protecting anyone inside absolutely — and the honest prize is the forest defended, the captured wealth held to account, and the harm documented, not a project stopped from within.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot safely resist inside a conflict-torn, resource-captured state, and you must never ask anyone to. What can be done is to defend the forest and hold its captured wealth to account, from outside: invoke the international and transboundary conservation of the Congo Basin, press the diamonds, gold, and timber through the certification, conflict-mineral, and legality frameworks, document the resource-for-security capture for the international bodies, and work through the conservation and humanitarian partners — while protecting everyone inside absolutely and avoiding the conflict zones entirely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

The Central African Republic is among the most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. This is not a fight you win by domestic organising — that is impossible and perilous in an active conflict. It is an external, conservation- and accountability-framed effort whose realistic prize is the forest defended and the captured wealth scrutinised, not a stop. Enter it understanding that no cause is worth a life, that the conflict zones and armed actors must be avoided entirely, and that the safety of everyone inside comes before every other consideration.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power over the resources rests with armed groups and foreign paramilitaries who hold the land, not with a functioning domestic system. The decisions resisters can reach are external — taken in the **international conservation bodies** that guard the forest, in the **certification and conflict-mineral frameworks** that govern diamonds and gold, in the **timber markets and legality regimes** abroad, and in the **international investigative, transparency, and humanitarian bodies** that scrutinise the capture. These, and the diaspora, are who can act from outside.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The extraction and the logging advance under the control of armed actors; there is no safe domestic hearing to contest. Resisters enter where the outside world touches the harm: the forest's conservation and World Heritage stakes, the diamonds' and gold's certification and due-diligence chains, the timber's markets, the international scrutiny of the resource-for-security arrangements. Each is a point of leverage reached from outside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the minerals: where the diamonds and gold flow, and which certification and due-diligence frameworks they must pass. Follow the timber: where the wood is sold, and what legality and sustainability standards those markets enforce. Follow the capture: which armed groups and paramilitaries trade extraction for security, and which international bodies can document and sanction it. The leverage lies in the certification chains, the timber standards, the conservation stakes, and the international scrutiny.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight has collapsed in much of the country. The watchers resisters can engage are external: the international conservation bodies and the transboundary World Heritage system, the Kimberley-style diamond certification and conflict-mineral frameworks, the timber-legality regimes, the international investigative and transparency organisations, the humanitarian and human-rights bodies, and the diaspora. These are the institutions a careful, external case is built to reach.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Central African effort yields a domestic "win," and honesty requires saying so — the resources are captured and the land is at war. What the external tools realistically deliver is defence and accountability: a treasured forest watched and its logging exposed, the conflict diamonds and gold pressed through certification, the timber's markets held to legality, the resource-for-security capture documented before the

world. The single most decisive move is **rigorous, safely-gathered documentation**, because every external lever — the conservation bodies, the certification frameworks, the timber markets, the investigative organisations — responds to credible evidence, and because such evidence can be gathered without endangering anyone inside. Nothing here is fast, and no project is likely to be stopped from within. But a global forest and captured wealth give the world a genuine reason and duty to act.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the logging, the poaching, the mining, the capture of resources for conflict. **What international framework does it touch?** — conservation and World Heritage, diamond certification, conflict-mineral due diligence, timber legality. **Who outside shares the interest?** — the conservation partners, the certification bodies, the timber markets, the humanitarian and investigative organisations. **Which external channel reaches it?** — a conservation body, a certification framework, a market regulator, an investigative organisation. **How is everyone inside kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by keeping all work external, avoiding the conflict zones, and exposing no one. Pick the harm where the international handle is clearest and safest.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, all gathered safely and from outside where possible. **Layer one: the harm** — the logging and poaching documented by satellite and by the conservation partners, the mining and its conflict links, the capture arrangements. **Layer two: the framework** — the conservation and World Heritage stakes, the certification and conflict-mineral standards, the timber-legality regimes the harm offends. **Layer three: the channel and the protection** — which external body to reach, and the absolute rule that no person inside is named, exposed, or endangered, and the conflict zones avoided. A case built on satellite imagery, conservation data, and the certification chains — needing no one inside — is one that reaches the levers without endangering anyone.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: satellite imagery of the logging, the conservation partners' wildlife and poaching data, the mining and its conflict links. Gather the **framework record**: the conservation and World Heritage designations, the diamond certification and conflict-mineral standards, the timber-legality regimes. Gather the **capture record**: the resource-for-security arrangements, documented through international investigative and transparency organisations. Gather the **channel record**: the conservation partners, the certification bodies, the timber markets, the humanitarian and investigative organisations, the diaspora. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm every source is external and safe, the conflict zones avoided, and no one inside exposed.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE INTERNATIONAL AND CONSERVATION COALITION

The coalition here is external, because it must be. Build it from the **international conservation partners and the transboundary programmes** that work the Congo Basin; the **certification, conflict-mineral, and transparency organisations** that govern the minerals; the **timber-market and legality campaigners** who

can reach the wood's buyers; and the **humanitarian, investigative, and diaspora networks** that document and amplify. Build carefully, protect every source and any contact inside, and never in a way that draws in or exposes anyone in the conflict zones.

STEP 4: CONSERVATION, CERTIFICATION & ACCOUNTABILITY LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are external, indirect, and partial, and the resources are captured, so the prize is defence and accountability, not a stop.

The Transboundary Forest Defence

The Congo Basin forest and its wildlife can be defended through **international and transboundary conservation** — the protected areas, the Sangha Trinational and the World Heritage stakes, the conservation partners who watch the elephants and gorillas and document the logging and poaching. Watch it, document it, and raise it with the bodies and partners that guard it.

The Diamond, Mineral, and Timber Standards

The diamonds and gold that fund the conflict can be pressed through the **certification and conflict-mineral due-diligence frameworks**, and the logging held to **international timber-legality and sustainability standards** in the markets its wood reaches. Press the captured wealth through the standards its outputs must pass on the way to the world.

The Resource-for-Security Scrutiny

The **capture of resources for security** can be documented and scrutinised through international investigative, transparency, and sanctions bodies. Pursued together — the forest defence, the certification standards, and the capture scrutiny — these external levers defend the forest and hold the captured wealth to account, while every person inside is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the conservation bodies**: here is a globally treasured forest under logging and poaching pressure, and here is the transboundary obligation. **For the certification and conflict-mineral frameworks**: here are diamonds and gold funding conflict, and here is the standard they fail. **For the timber markets**: here is wood that may fail the legality standards you enforce. **For the investigative and transparency bodies**: here is resource wealth captured for security, documented. **The golden rule**: keep everything external and safe, argue the conservation stakes and the standards, avoid the conflict zones, and protect every name inside absolutely.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, carried entirely from outside. Frame the story around the **global forest treasure and the captured wealth**: a second-largest rainforest under threat, its elephants and gorillas, and the diamonds, gold, and timber funding conflict. Carry it through international conservation and investigative outlets, and the humanitarian and diaspora networks. A few cautions govern everything: never name or endanger anyone inside; rely on satellite imagery, conservation data, and international investigation; keep it factual; avoid the conflict actors; and let the forest, the wildlife, and the certification failures carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external, documentary, and absolutely protective of anyone inside.

8A — To an international conservation body: document the logging or poaching of the Congo Basin forest and invoke the transboundary and World Heritage obligation.

8B — To a diamond certification framework: present the evidence of conflict diamonds and ask how they meet the certification standard.

8C — To a conflict-mineral or due-diligence body: set out the gold or minerals funding conflict and request scrutiny.

8D — To a timber market or legality regime: flag wood that may fail the legality and sustainability standards, with the evidence.

8E — To an investigative or transparency organisation: document the resource-for-security capture and request investigation.

8F — To a conservation partner in the region: share the documented forest and wildlife case and ask for engagement.

8G — To the humanitarian and diaspora networks: share the case and ask for amplification and safe channels.

8H — To the international public: summarise the forest treasure and the captured wealth, and ask for pressure — never exposing anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: pull the satellite imagery and conservation data on the logging or poaching; identify the certification, mineral, or timber framework the harm touches; write the one-page forest-and-accountability case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the conservation partners, the certification frameworks, and the timber markets. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the international conservation partners and the investigative organisations first — they act safely from outside. Throughout, avoid the conflict zones and expose no one inside.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but at war and captured: armed groups and paramilitaries hold the resources, and domestic opposition is impossible. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a stop, but defence and accountability through the levers the capture cannot reach. Lean on the conservation stakes, the certification and timber standards, and the international scrutiny, all pursued from outside. And accept the honest possibility of losing on any front — the logging may continue, the minerals may still fund the fighting — while still defending the forest and documenting the harm, and protecting, always and above all, the people.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the capture is not corruption at the margins but the system: the resources are held by armed groups and foreign paramilitaries who trade extraction for security. Respond only through the **external channels**:

the certification and conflict-mineral frameworks, the timber standards, the international investigative and sanctions bodies, the documented record. Never through domestic action or contact with the armed actors. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything. The Central African Republic is torn by active conflict with armed groups and foreign paramilitaries who hold the land. Work through the international, conservation, and external channels entirely; never expose or endanger anyone inside; avoid the conflict zones and armed actors entirely; frame the work as international conservation and accountability; and handle the armed groups and the conflict only through the documented international record. Protection is not one concern among others — it is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, all from outside. The documented harm feeds the forest defence, the certification and timber scrutiny, and the capture accountability at once; the international and conservation coalition organises alongside; the media carries the forest-and-accountability frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the satellite and conservation documentation and identify the frameworks; **months two to six**, engage the conservation bodies, the certification and timber standards, and the investigative organisations; **beyond**, sustain the external defence and accountability. The core discipline: external, conservation- and accountability-framed, conflict-avoiding, and absolute in protecting anyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Central African Republic is among the most dangerous and captured grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a harm can be stopped from within, or that domestic opposition is possible, or that the capture is easily broken — none of that is true, and the land is at war. What it claims is narrower and real: that the Congo Basin forest is a global treasure the world has an obligation to defend; that the diamonds, gold, and timber answer to certification, conflict-mineral, and legality frameworks a case can invoke; that the resource-for-security capture can be documented and scrutinised internationally; and that all of this can be pursued from outside — through the conservation partners, the certification frameworks, the timber markets, and the investigative bodies — without ever exposing a single person inside. The levers are external and partial, and the prize is defence and accountability, not a stop from within. But for a conflict-torn, resource-captured state that holds a global forest, that external, conservation- and accountability-framed, protective work is not a lesser ambition — it is the only responsible and effective one.